despite the numbers not tallying with the facts. Not only were modernised apartments included in the figures, but places in old people's homes and workers' hostels were also erroneously listed as newly built apartments.

The apartment issue was one of the few domestic topics that interested Honecker. As the year progressed, he paid remarkably little attention to local matters, including the startling revelation that forty-four people in the GDR were infected with the AIDS virus, and three had died from the disease. Concerns were also raised about the slack discipline and increased drunkenness among the Soviet forces stationed in the GDR, a problem which forced Soviet Defence Minister Dmitry Yazov to issue a reprimand.

Meanwhile, on 1 July, the Soviet Union voted to end the Communist Party's monopoly on economic and other non-political power and to further economic changes toward a less rigidly Marxist-Leninist economy. As events moved at a frightening speed, Honecker sought comfort from like-minded allies including Romanian leader Nicolae Ceausescu, who flew into the GDR during November to receive the Karl Marx Medal for his 'achievements'. Commenting on the trip, the London Times opined that because Gorbachev had not articulated a coherent policy toward Eastern Europe, Ceausescu was able to join Honecker in 'claiming to be the true keepers of the communist world', and provide opponents of the Gorbachev reforms inside the Soviet Union with a stick to beat him with as the reforms started to go sour. 'So long as old-style leaders remain in power in Eastern Europe, there is a fifth column ready and waiting to assist a retreat in Moscow.'32 During their talks, Honecker told Ceausescu:

If people hold the opinion that the history of the communist world movement, particularly in the socialist countries, is a history of crimes they are not only on the false path but are even working into the hands of those who disfigure the face of socialism … who want to cast a shadow on socialism.33